

Remembering Jaspal Rana, through a Saturday conversation

That was my introduction to Jaspal. Years later, it remains the perfect window into the **man behind the medals.**

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I don't quite remember the nitty-gritty of my first conversation with Jaspal Rana. The year, tournament and circumstances have all blurred.

However, there's no mistaking that it was on a Saturday, approximately four to five years ago, that I placed my first call to him after introducing myself over a text message.

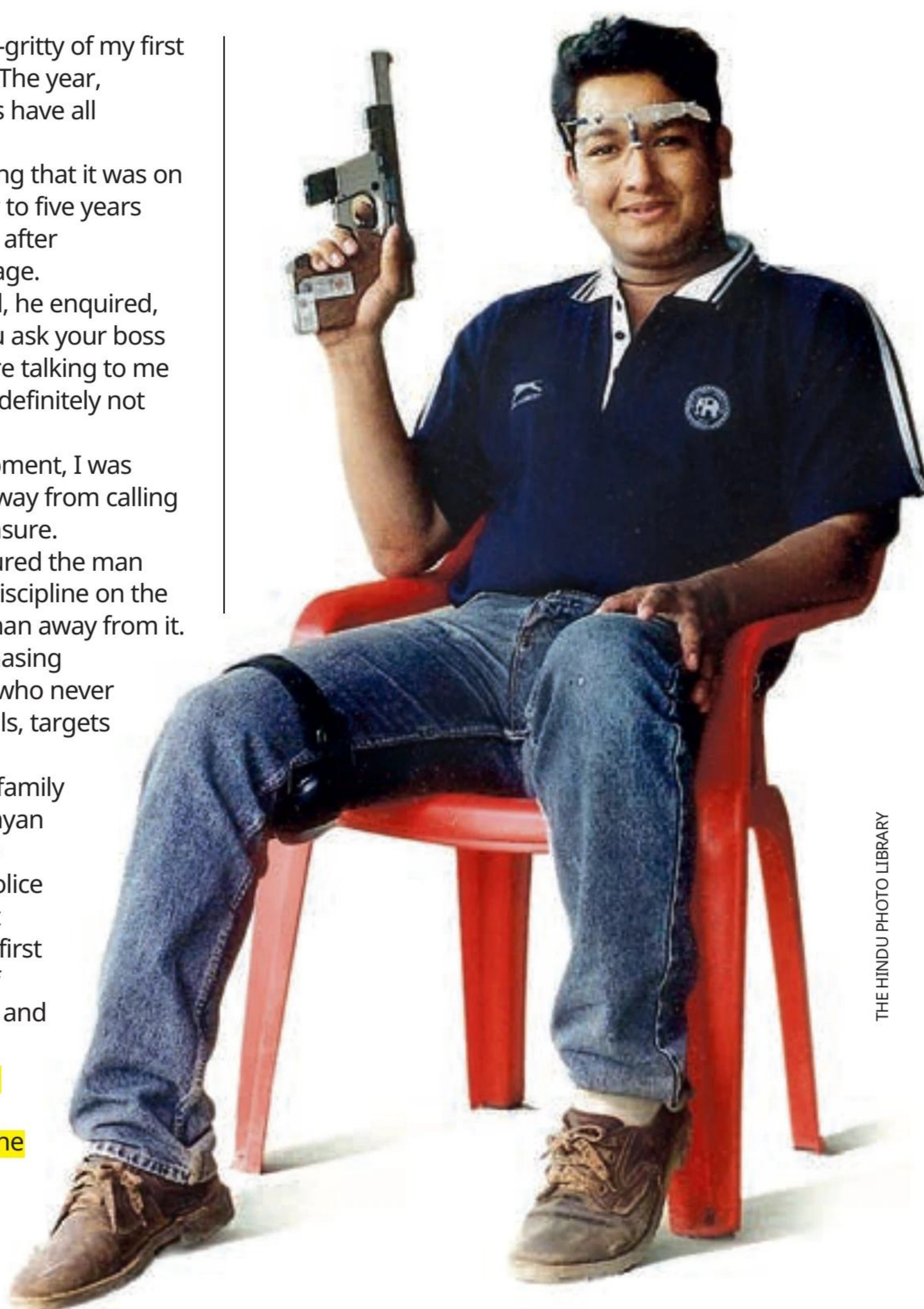
For when Jaspal answered the call, he enquired, almost incredulously, "Why don't you ask your boss for weekend day-offs, man? If you are talking to me on a Saturday evening, something's definitely not right."

I laughed. He didn't. And for a moment, I was almost sure he was half a thought away from calling my Editor and expressing his displeasure.

That little moment perfectly captured the man Jaspal was. A champion of ruthless discipline on the shooting range, yet remarkably human away from it. Someone who could spend hours chasing perfection with a pistol in hand, but who never forgot that life existed beyond medals, targets and deadlines.

Born in 1976, Jaspal grew up in a family steeped in shooting. His father, Narayan Singh Rana, a 1971 war veteran who served in the Indo-Tibetan Border Police and later became Uttarakhand's first Sports Minister in 2000, was Jaspal's first guide as he picked up his weapon of choice, a pistol. His siblings, Sushma and Subhash, took up the sport as well.

Jaspal was only 12 when he made his national debut. And merely six years later, he had already bagged the Arjuna Award, the country's second-highest sporting accolade. Three years later, he was conferred the Padma Shri, India's



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